

Song Dynasty

With towering Buddhist pagodas, great stone and wooden bridges, lavish tombs and extravagant palaces, China's Song Dynasty (960–1279) became noted for its sophisticated building developments, such as the 110-metre (360-ft) pagoda in Bianjing, capital of the Northern Song. Cities such as Bianjing were built on square or rectangular plans, with walls of rammed earth topped by a mixture of broken brick, tiles and crushed stone.

Pagodas developed from purely wooden structures to stone, brick and even cast iron. The Iron Pagoda of Yuquan Temple in Hubei Province (built c.1061) incorporates 53 tonnes of cast metal in its 21.3-metre (70-ft) structure. The Liuhe or 'Six Harmonies' Pagoda in the Southern Song capital of Hangzhou, in Zhejiang Province, is another fine example of pagoda architecture from the time (opposite). Standing 60 metres (197 ft) tall, it was built with a red-brick frame and 13 stages of wooden eaves. Internally, however, the pagoda has just seven stories, each with an elaborately decorated ceiling.

